ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

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Side Hustles and Freelancing: Earn Without Damaging Your Degree

Find a skill, price it fairly, and get paid without being scammed

MONEY & CAREER

Money & Career

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Free to download. No fee, no payment step, no watermark.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Many students want income but start with no skill and no plan. This pack helps you choose a realistic hustle, build one service people actually pay for, price it, find your first five clients and avoid the scams that target young freelancers.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Choose a side hustle that fits your skills, timetable and capital.
- Package one clear service and price it with a simple method.
- Find and convert your first clients without spamming.
- Protect yourself with deposits, written scope and clear delivery terms.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Pick a realistic hustle

Match the hustle to your time, capital and existing skill.

- Service hustles need time and skill, not capital: writing, design, tutoring, virtual assistance, transcription, social media management.
- Product hustles need capital and storage: reselling, food, print and design.
- Skill-based hustles pay more over time because the skill compounds.
- Avoid anything requiring upfront payment to 'unlock' jobs.
- Avoid gambling, betting syndicates and get-rich-quick schemes presented as business.

- Choose one and give it ninety days before judging it.

Package and price

Clients buy outcomes, not effort.

- Describe the service as a deliverable: 'a 1,500-word SEO article with five sources'.
- Set a minimum price rather than charging by hour at the start.
- Calculate your cost of delivery: data, transport, software, time.
- Charge a deposit for custom work, especially with new clients.
- Raise your price when demand exceeds your capacity, not when you feel brave.
- Put scope, revisions and deadline in writing for every job.

> **Cheap clients are expensive**
> A client who argues about a fair price before hiring usually argues about everything after delivery.

Find clients and get paid safely

Your first clients are usually closer than you think.

- Start with people who already know your work: classmates, departments, small businesses nearby.
- Build a simple portfolio of three samples, even if self-initiated.
- Use a clear profile and one platform consistently.
- Send specific messages referencing the client's actual need.
- Receive payment before delivering final files, or split into deposit and balance.
- Keep records of income and be transparent about it.

Earning without losing the degree

A side hustle is worth doing only if it survives contact with your timetable. The test is simple: can you do it in fixed hours that do not compete with your highest-value study time? Work that expands to fill every evening will cost you the semester.

The realistic options for students are skills-based and local: tutoring, writing and editing, graphic design, photography, social media management, tailoring, repairs, food sales, delivery and transcription. Each has a low entry cost and a market you can reach on foot or through acquaintances.

Choose by skill you already have, not by what sounds lucrative. A mediocre photographer competing with professionals earns nothing; a patient mathematics tutor with a good reputation is booked out before examinations.

The business basics nobody teaches

Price by the job, not by the hour, and calculate your costs first. If a design job takes four hours, requires data and electricity, and the client wants three revisions, the price must cover all of it. Students routinely underprice because they count only their time.

Get a deposit before starting. Fifty per cent is normal for freelance work and protects you from clients who disappear. Put the scope in writing - number of revisions, delivery date, format - because the difference between a good job and an endless one is usually an unclear agreement.

Keep records from the first naira: income, expenses, and who owes what. A notebook is enough. It protects you in disputes and shows you which work is actually profitable.

> **Say no to scope creep**
> "That is outside what we agreed - I can do it for an additional fee" is a professional sentence. Working for free to be liked is how freelancers burn out.

Reputation, payment and risk

Most student work comes through trust networks: classmates, lecturers, church and mosque communities, family. That means your reputation is your marketing, and one unfinished job travels further than ten good ones.

Payment risk is real. Use bank transfers rather than cash where possible, keep screenshots, agree a delivery date, and withhold final files until final payment for work where that is reasonable. For larger jobs, split into milestones.

Understand the legal basics: you cannot sell work you did not create, you should not use pirated software for paid work, and income may be taxable depending on the amount and your circumstances. Ask before assuming.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Pricing a freelance job

A client wants five social media graphics, delivered in a week.

1. Estimate time: one hour per graphic plus two hours of revisions, so seven hours.
2. Calculate costs: data, electricity, software, transport to meet the client.
3. Decide a target hourly rate that makes the work worth your time.
4. Set a price that covers time plus costs plus a margin for the revision risk.
5. State the scope in writing: five graphics, two revisions, delivery date and format.
6. Request fifty per cent upfront.

> **What to carry forward**
> Time plus costs plus revision risk, agreed in writing, with a deposit.

2. Handling a client who will not pay

You delivered work and the client has stopped responding.

1. Send one clear, polite message restating the amount, the agreed date and the work delivered.
2. Attach the screenshots of the agreement and delivery.
3. Set a firm date for payment and state the consequence - withholding further work or files.
4. Escalate through a mutual contact if one exists.
5. Record the client in your own notes and do not work for them again without prepayment.
6. Learn the lesson: deposit first, next time.

> **What to carry forward**
> Documented, polite, escalating pressure works better than anger. And it starts with a deposit.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Explain how a student should decide whether to take on paid work during the semester.

10 marks

1. Fixed hours that do not compete with high-value study time.
2. Skill match and market demand.
3. Effect on attendance and assessment deadlines.
4. Explicit decision about what will be sacrificed.

Q2. Why should a freelancer take a deposit and state scope in writing?

10 marks

1. Deposits protect against non-payment and confirm commitment.
2. Written scope limits revisions and disputes.
3. Both convert a hopeful arrangement into an agreement.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Freelancing. Working for clients on specific jobs rather than as an employee.

Scope. The agreed extent of work to be delivered.

Deposit. An upfront payment securing a job and reducing non-payment risk.

Scope creep. Unpaid expansion of a job beyond what was agreed.

Milestone. A payment stage tied to a delivered portion of work.

Cost of delivery. The expenses incurred to complete a job.

Reputation. The standing that generates repeat and referred work.

Invoice. A document requesting payment for work delivered.

Retainer. A recurring fee for an agreed ongoing service.

Portfolio. A collection of work demonstrating your capability.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Skill

What can you sell?

- List three skills you have.
- Ask three people what they would pay for.
- Choose one and set a price.

Week 2 - Offer

Finding clients.

- Write a three-line offer.
- Tell ten people.
- Build a simple portfolio of three items.

Week 3 - Deliver

Professionalism.

- Write a scope agreement for one job.
- Take a deposit.
- Deliver on the agreed date.

Week 4 - Record

Learning.

- Record income and costs.
- Calculate the real hourly return.
- Decide whether to continue.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- A freelancing guide covering pricing and contracts.
- Your institution's rules on student employment.
- A short guide to invoicing and record keeping.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Name two service hustles with low startup capital.

Answer: Tutoring and freelance writing. Virtual assistance, transcription and social media management are also low-capital.

2. Why is a written scope important?

Answer: It prevents endless revisions and disagreements about what was promised.

3. How should you price your first service?

Answer: Calculate delivery cost, check what comparable services charge, set a minimum acceptable price and avoid underpricing to win work.

4. What is a deposit for?

Answer: It reduces the risk of a client refusing to pay after work has begun and confirms commitment.

5. Why avoid hustles that require paying to get a job?

Answer: Legitimate employers pay workers; upfront fees are a common fraud pattern.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] List three skills you already have.
- [ ] Choose one service and write its deliverable in one sentence.
- [ ] Create three sample works for your portfolio.
- [ ] Write a client message template that is specific, not generic.
- [ ] Set your minimum price and deposit policy.
- [ ] Pitch five potential clients this week.
- [ ] Record every job, payment and client contact.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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